

SENATE JOINT RESOLUTION 440

By Hatcher

A RESOLUTION to honor the Heritage Lady Mountaineers girls' basketball team upon winning the 2025 TSSAA Division I, Class 3A state championship.

WHEREAS, it is fitting that this General Assembly should salute those student athletes who, through their extraordinary efforts, have distinguished themselves as true champions of whom we can all be proud; and

WHEREAS, one such exemplary group of lasses is the Lady Mountaineers girls' basketball team of Heritage High School in Blount County, whose members have proven themselves to be the fiercest of competitors and truly worthy of admiration by winning the 2025 TSSAA Division I, Class 3A state championship, marking the first team state championship in school history and the first girls' basketball state championship won by an area team since Porter (one of Heritage's predecessor schools) claimed the title in 1969; and

WHEREAS, entering regional competition as District 5 champions, the Lady Mountaineers trounced Red Bank 79-27 in the quarterfinals and rolled over South-Doyle 70-55 in the semifinal round; and

WHEREAS, Heritage vanquished Lenoir City 57-51 in the regional final to advance to the sectional round, where the Lady Mountaineers overpowered Livingston Academy 71-56 to punch their ticket to the Big Dance; and

WHEREAS, at the Class 3A state tournament at MTSU's Murphy Center, Heritage crushed Portland 60-36 in the quarterfinals and then bested South Gibson 36-29 in their semifinal match-up to advance to the final; and

WHEREAS, Heritage's Carsyn Swaney, a Tennessee Miss Basketball finalist, suffered an injury in the semifinals and was unable to play in the championship game; switching tactics,

Coach Rick Howard emphasized the importance of the team's underclassmen in the face of adversity; and

WHEREAS, Isabella "Izzy" Hutsell set the tone for the championship game by singing in the opening of the National Anthem; her teammates responded, and the Lady Mountaineers creamed Northview Academy 63-43 to win the Gold Ball trophy that signifies a state champion and finish the campaign with a remarkable 35-2 record; and

WHEREAS, led by senior Chloe Heath, sophomores Kenley Coker, Faith Morris, and Katie Graves stepped up to the challenge and contributed offensively in their star's absence; and

WHEREAS, Aleyah Smyth put on a defensive clinic, and Emma Carswell and Olivia Boyce came off the bench to contribute both offensively and defensively; and

WHEREAS, in addition to the aforementioned hoopsters, the other team members expended significant energy and excitement in cheering their team on to a historic victory; these hardy Lady Mountaineers included Cheyann Morris, Allison Perry, Natalie Byrd, Isabella Hutsell, Makenna Miller, Gracelyn Livingston, and Micah Parker; and

WHEREAS, Coach Howard and his assistant coaches, Jordan Ballard, Jay Coker, and Kirsten Roberts, displayed strategic leadership, and their ability to adapt to every challenge was crucial in ultimately leading Heritage to a state championship; and

WHEREAS, the Lady Mountaineers were fortunate to enjoy the unfailing support of their families, fans, fellow students, and the entire Blount County community; and

WHEREAS, the members of the Heritage girls' basketball team epitomize all that is good in today's student athletes, as they have achieved a premier level of success in competition while exhibiting the highest degree of character in all aspects of life; and

WHEREAS, Heritage's success was built on a foundation of unity and a shared goal, and the team chemistry among the players was evident in every game, as they treated the Lady Mountaineer program as a sisterhood; and

WHEREAS, we find it appropriate to acknowledge and applaud the Heritage Lady Mountaineers for their outstanding season on the hardwood; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE SENATE OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES CONCURRING, that we honor and congratulate the Heritage Lady Mountaineers girls' basketball team upon winning the 2025 TSSAA Division I, Class 3A state championship, the first team state title in school history and an inspiration for future generations, and extend to them our best wishes for every continued success in all their future endeavors.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.